

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1987-03-10

To an individual b ahá'í

1 dear b ahá'í f riend,
2 1987 and has asked us to convey on its behalf the following in response to
3 the points you have raised.
4 it is not advisable for bahá'í institutions or individuals to initiate actions
5 designed to prod government leaders to urge their government or the lead-ers of
other governments to convene the world conference called for by bahá'u'lláh and echoed in
The Promise of World Peace. T wo points should
6 be borne in mind in this regard: (1) because of the political gravity of the
7 decisions implied by this call and the differing political attitudes which it evokes,
such actions on the part of the bahá'í community would embroil
8 the friends in partisan politics. There is quite a difference between identi-
9 fying, as does the peace Statement, the need for a convocation of world
10 leaders and initiating the political processes towards its realization. (2) in
11 the writings of the faith (e.g., the closing passages of The Promised Day Is
12 Come), it is clear that the establishment of the lesser peace, of which the
13 conference of leaders will be a related event, will come about independently
14 of any b ahá'í plan or action. This is not to say that b ahá'ís should be inert.
15 indeed, bahá'ís may promote the concept of the lesser peace with all that
16 it implies without engaging in the political processes which its realization
17 will require.
18 The house of justice feels that the task before the bahá'ís is to prepare
19 the ground for the transition from the present system of national sover-eignty to a
system of world government. This requires a number of related
20 activities which have been indicated in the goals of previous and present plans of the
community based on 'Abdu'l-b ahá's Tablets of the divine plan.
21 The activities which will indirectly prepare the world to make the final stride

22 include the following.
23 The establishment as rapidly as possible of firmly grounded, efficiently
24 functioning local Spiritual Assemblies in every part of the world, so that
25 seekers everywhere will have a point of reference to which they can turn for 18.1

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20 29guidance and for the Teachings of the faith. This implies a vast increase in

bahá'í membership. Although the canadian and many other bahá'í com-

21 munities have achieved remarkable progress, much work is required to bring
22 the bahá'í institutions all over the world to the degree of maturation that is
23 needed.

24 A second important activity is the deepening of the believers, of all ages,

25 in their understanding of and obedience to the Teachings of the faith. A

26 third is the proclamation of the faith to all strata of society, and in par-

27 ticular to those in authority and to leaders of thought so that those who hold the
direction of peoples in their hands will learn accurately about the

28 nature and tenets of the faith and will grow to respect it and implement

29 its principles. A fourth is the promotion of bahá'í scholarship, so that an

30 increasing number of believers will be able to analyze the problems of man-kind in
every field and to show how the Teachings solve them. A fifth is the

31 development of relations between the bahá'í international community and

32 the united Nations, both directly with the highest united Nations institu-

33 tions and at a grass-roots level in areas of rural development, education, etc.

34 These different activities, which began a long time ago and are still go-

35 ing on, coupled with the presentation of The Promise of World Peace to the

36 leaders of the world, will gradually bring about circumstances which will indicate the
direction of subsequent actions. The house of justice will ad-

37 vise the bahá'í world when the time is ripe for such actions. The unpredict-

38 ability of certain events in the world, which are likely to change the current course of
certain processes, makes it impracticable for the house of justice

39 to respond with precision to some of your questions.

40 The house of justice in its message to the bahá'ís of the world dated 2

41 january 1986 referred to Shoghi effendi's perception of a dialectic of victory

42 and crisis in the organic life of the cause. This indicates the instrumentality

43 of the forces of opposition which will help to bring about, over a period of time,

conditions necessary for the local and National Spiritual Assemblies

44 to act effectively as local and National houses of justice.

45 The stages of the evolution of these institutions, which will synchronize

46 with the establishment of the lesser peace, are indicated in the writings of

47 the beloved guardian, such as in the following extract:

48 Not only will the present-day Spiritual Assemblies be styled differently in future,

but they will be enabled also to add to their present functions those powers, duties, and

prerogatives necessitated by the 18.5

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19 message from The Universal House of Justice

20 Recognition of the faith of bahá'u'lláh, not merely as one of the rec-

21 ognized religious systems of the world, but as the State religion of an

22 independent and Sovereign power.

(The World Order of Bahá'u'lláh, pp. 6-7)

your specific question about whether or not bahá'ís in North America

23 "are permitted to run for election to school boards, town or municipal coun-

24 cils, hospital boards and for local enforcement officer positions" should be

25 answered by the National Assemblies concerned.

The completion of the buildings on the Arc "which will synchronize

26 with two no less significant developments—the establishment of the lesser

27 peace and the evolution of bahá'í national and local institutions—the one

28 outside and the other within the bahá'í world"18-1 speaks, as you have rightly

29 perceived, "to the readiness of the bahá'í Administrative order to manage

30 the ever-growing and complex affairs of the cause as well as an increased
31 capacity to interface with the non-bahá'í world and its institutions.”
32 regarding the question in the final paragraph of your letter, the follow-
33 ing reply was written on behalf of the beloved guardian in a letter dated 14
34 march 1939 to an individual believer.

**your view that the lesser peace will come about through the political
efforts of the states and nations of the world, and independently of
35 any direct bahá'í plan or effort, and the most great peace established
36 through the instrumentality of the believers, and by the direct opera-
tion of the laws and principles revealed by bahá'u'lláh and the func-
bahá'í Super State—your view on this subject is quite correct and in
full accord with the pronouncements of the guardian as embodied in
the “unfolding of world civilization.”¹⁸⁻²**

37 The fact that the bahá'í institutions will not be directly involved in the
38 eventual convocation of world leaders and in effecting the political unity
39 of nations does not mean that the bahá'ís are standing aside and waiting

40 18-1. mbw , p. 74

41 18-2. See wob, pp. 161–206.^{18.9}

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20 1 for the lesser peace to come before they do something about the peace of
21 mankind. indeed, by promoting the principles of the faith, which are indis-
22 pensable to the maintenance of peace, and by fashioning the instruments of
23 the bahá'í Administrative order, which we are told by the beloved guardian
24 is the pattern for future society, the bahá'ís are constantly engaged in laying
25 the groundwork for a permanent peace, the most great peace being their
26 ultimate goal.

27 with loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

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Execution of Two Bahá'ís in Iran

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]